



City of Cambridge

POR 2026-119
FIRST IN COUNCIL
June 8, 2026

COUNCILLOR SIMMONS
COUNCILLOR MCGOVERN
COUNCILLOR FLAHERTY

WHEREAS: Hidden behind and between properties near Winthrop Street, Charlie's Kitchen Beer Garden, and Eliot Street is a dry-laid fieldstone retaining wall known as the Old Stone Wall, believed to have been built in the late 1700s and early 1800s to help channel the spring-fed Town Creek toward the Charles River and stabilize what is now Winthrop Square; and

WHEREAS: This wall is one of the most significant surviving physical links to the earliest planned settlement of Newtowne, which later became Cambridge, and has been described by the Cambridge Historical Commission as the largest and most significant historic stone wall in Harvard Square; and

WHEREAS: Despite its historic significance, much of the wall is hidden from public view and remains unknown to many residents, visitors, and passersby, making it all too easy for this important piece of Cambridge history to be overlooked, neglected, or lost; and

WHEREAS: A portion of the wall collapsed in 2020 and has not yet been repaired, while the remaining structure continues to face threats from age, erosion, weather, surrounding development, and severe rodent activity that may be further destabilizing the site; and

WHEREAS: An earlier repair effort stalled after the estimated cost exceeded the available Community Preservation Act funding and no final agreement was reached among the City and abutting property owners regarding funding, access, and long-term responsibility; and

WHEREAS: As Cambridge approaches its 400th anniversary in 2030, the City should make every reasonable effort to protect historic resources that tell the story of its earliest settlement, while also addressing any related public health and safety concerns; now therefore be it

ORDERED: That the City Manager be and hereby is requested to confer with the Cambridge Historical Commission, the Law Department, the Department of Public Works, Inspectional Services, the Cambridge Public Health Department, Community Preservation Act staff, the Harvard Square Business Association, and the owners of properties abutting the Old Stone Wall, for the purpose of developing a practical plan to stabilize, preserve, and restore this historic resource; and be it further

ORDERED: That said plan should include an updated assessment of the wall's current condition, estimated repair costs, immediate stabilization needs, the impact of rodent activity and other environmental conditions, and the legal or practical responsibilities of the

City and abutting property owners; and be it further

ORDERED: That the City Manager be and hereby is requested to identify potential funding and partnership options, including Community Preservation Act historic preservation funds, private contributions, preservation grants, easements, public-access agreements, and other public-private partnership models; and be it further

ORDERED: That the City Manager be and hereby is requested to report back to the City Council with findings, options, and recommended next steps within 120 days.

A true copy;

ATTEST:-

A handwritten signature in cursive script, appearing to read "Paula M. Crane".

Paula M. Crane,
Interim City Clerk



City of Cambridge

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